

MGT 207: Operations Management for Competitive Advantage

Fall 2026 - UC Riverside School of Business

Instructor: Danko Turcic

Fall 2026

Course Overview

- **Instructor:** Danko Turcic, Associate Professor of Operations Management
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- **Office:** School of Business Building, 421
- **Office Hours:** W 1:00 PM-2:00 PM (in person) and Tue 12:00 PM-1:00 PM (Zoom ID: 752 601 2800); or, by appointment.
- **Meeting Time:** W 2:00 PM to 4:50 PM
- **Classroom:** AGSM 118

Course Description and Objectives

Description

Focuses on managing activities in product/service creation (design, production, distribution) to optimize processes for competitive advantage.

Objectives

- Understand operations management's role in organizations.
- Learn how it provides a competitive edge through optimized decision making.
- Enhance problem-solving skills.

AI Tools Like ChatGPT vs. Analytical Thinking

- **Large Language Models (LLMs):** Power tools like ChatGPT for text generation and insights.
- Strengths: Answer questions, suggest ideas based on data patterns.
- Limitation: **Don't replace analytical thinking**—lack structured reasoning for complex decisions.

Key Point

Human judgment is essential for operations management problem-solving.

Analytical Models vs. LLM Algorithms

Analytical Models

- **Goal:** Optimize (e.g., maximize profit, minimize cost).
- **Algorithms:** Mathematical (e.g., linear programming).
- **Example:** Compute optimal inventory levels.

Conclusion

Optimization needs specialized logic LLMs don't have.

LLMs

- **Goal:** Predict/generate text from patterns.
- **Algorithms:** Neural networks (e.g., transformers).
- **Example:** Describe supply chain, not optimize it.

Why Optimization Skills Remain Critical

- LLMs **assist** (e.g., explain concepts) but can't:
 - Formulate objectives/constraints.
 - Solve structured problems iteratively.
- **Analytical skills:** Provide a competitive edge in operations.
- **Takeaway:** Learn optimization—AI supports, doesn't replace it.

A case in point



- **Website:** <https://eLearn.ucr.edu> (homework and grades)
- **GitHub Repo:** <https://github.com/dxt48/MGT-207> (class notes, etc.)
- **Harvard Course Pack:** <https://hbsp.harvard.edu/import/1456740> (course pack)
- **Helpful References:**
 - Heizer, Render, Munson: *Operations Management: Sustainability and Supply Chain Management* (any recent edition)
 - Render, Stair, Balakrishnan: *Managerial Decision Modeling with Spreadsheets* (any edition)

Grading Policy

Components:

Component	Weight
Cases analysis	50%
Final Case	20%
Homework	30%

Letter Grades:

Scores Between		Grade
97%	100%	A+
94%	97%	A
90%	94%	A-
87%	90%	B+
84%	87%	B
80%	84%	B-
77%	80%	C+
74%	77%	C
70%	74%	C-
67%	70%	D+
64%	67%	D
60%	64%	D-
0%	60%	F

Case Studies and Purchasing Details

Course Pack Purchase

- Each student **must purchase** the Harvard Business Publishing Course Pack: <https://hbsp.harvard.edu/import/1456740>.
- Class materials are distributed via GitHub: <https://github.com/dxt48/MGT-207>.
- Use the **exact name and email** as on Canvas—no credit if they don't match (no exceptions).
- No funding or discounts provided.

Grading for Simulation-Based Cases

- **Relative Performance:** Graded by relative class performance using percentile ranks.
- **Scores:** $\geq 95\%$ -ile: 100%, 90-94.9: 95%, 85-89.9: 91%, 80-84.9: 88%, 75-79.9: 86%, $> 0-74.9$: 80%.
- **Minimum:** Valid attempts receive at least 80%.
- **Drops:** The lowest three case scores will be dropped (excluding

Homework & Final Case

- **Homework Format:** Quantitative focus, posted on Canvas.
- **Homework Attempts:** Up to 2; final attempt graded.
- **Final Case:** Take-home case analysis, graded identical to regular cases.

Additional Issues

- Attendance
- Class videos
- Any questions?